



Pop it in there!

Each orbiter has a huge payload bay. You could park a school bus in this cavity, which holds the satellites, experiments, and laboratories that need to be taken into space.

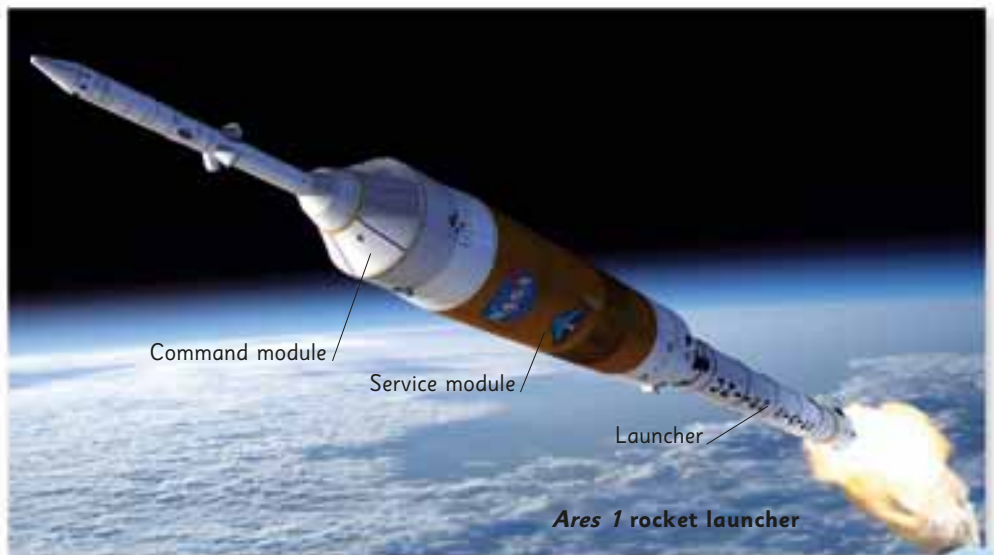
The payload's doors open once the shuttle is in orbit.



Space shuttle *Endeavour* landing at Edwards Air Force Base, California, USA.

The future shuttle

NASA are currently working on designs for a new orbiter, the *Orion* Crew Exploration Vehicle (CEV). It will travel into space on an *Ares I* rocket launcher, and carry up to six astronauts on each mission.



The orbiter fleet

Five orbiters were built. Two have been lost in tragic accidents.



Columbia first flew in 1981. It disintegrated on re-entry in 2003.



Challenger was destroyed in 1986, just 73 seconds after launch.



Discovery first flew in 1984. It marked the 100th shuttle mission in 2000.



Atlantis first flew in 1985. It has completed more than 25 missions.



Endeavour was built to replace *Challenger*. It first flew in 1992.

A safe landing

Shuttles glide down, belly first. Once the orbiter touches the runway, it releases a 12 m (40 ft) drag chute to slow it down.